



Preliminary Exam Handbook

EFFECTIVE AY 2025-2026

POLYTECHNIC GRADUATE EDUCATION COMMITTEE (APPROVED: 03-27-2025)

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The Polytechnic Preliminary Examination Handbook

1. Overview of the Preliminary Examination Handbook

The preliminary examination handbook was prepared by the Polytechnic Graduate Education Committee and is effective for the Catalog Term FA 2025. The purpose of the handbook is to give a concise statement of the following areas related to the preliminary exam:

- a) rationale and purpose.
- b) procedures for administering the exam.
- c) procedures for taking the preliminary exam.
- d) grading criteria and procedures, and
- e) procedures for administering a second preliminary exam.

Ultimate responsibility for the preliminary exam structure and framework, and all other aspects of graduate education in the Polytechnic resides with the Polytechnic's Graduate Education Committee which represents the graduate faculty of the College, subject to the approval of the Office of Graduate Studies and Postdoctoral Scholars.

The Polytechnic Graduate Education Committee oversees the process of administering the preliminary examination. Graduate students and their Committee Chair share responsibility for the organization and implementation of the preliminary exam.

2. Rationale and Purpose

The Preliminary Exam is intended to be a fair and rigorous test of a student's knowledge of broad areas covered by the coursework in the student's plan of study. The exam goes beyond a simple review of the content of courses; it asks the student to develop a reading list on a topic of the student's research that can be augmented by the Preliminary examining committee. The questions in the preliminary examination cover relevant aspects of study within the scope of the Polytechnic Institute and the larger discipline of Technology Studies. The Polytechnic Graduate Education Committee will ensure this requirement is fulfilled through a series of applicable examination questions. The student's responses need to integrate, synthesize, and interpret materials used in responding to the questions. The examination is designed to challenge students to reasonable intellectual limits.

3. Eligibility for Taking the Exam – Student Responsibilities

To become eligible to take the preliminary examination, the student must have an approved plan of study, satisfactorily completed most of the formal study, and satisfied any world language requirements. Satisfactory completion of any world language requirement is monitored and determined by the department. **In the Polytechnic, satisfactory completion is also indicated by good academic standing with at least a 3.0 GPA, no unresolved grades of less than B- in core courses and completed or will have in the semester that the Preliminary will occur, all departmental required courses.**

The preliminary examination should be scheduled as soon as possible and must be completed with at least two sessions of registration (including summer session) before the date of the doctoral final examination. For example, a doctoral student who passes the preliminary examination during a spring session is not eligible to take the doctoral final examination (provided that the student is registered for the subsequent summer session and fall session) before the following spring session. The Graduate Council recommends that full-time graduate students take the preliminary examination by the end of their third year of graduate

study.

The preliminary examining committee must consist of a minimum of three members of the graduate faculty. A majority of the committee members must have regular graduate faculty certification. All members of the examining committee are to be notified of the scheduled examination. Other faculty members may be requested by any member of the examining committee to participate, without vote, in the examination, and any interested faculty member may be present, without vote. Although only three committee members are required, if the committee has four or more members, a single member may withhold his or her signature of approval.

A preliminary examination passed by a student whose graduate study and/or professional activity has been inactive for five years or more is invalid.

4. Procedures for Administering the Exam – Examining Committee Responsibilities

The Polytechnic follows the University process under D. Establishing Examining Committees.¹

The preliminary committee will review, revise if necessary, and approve the reading list prepared by the student (within two weeks after receiving reading list from student).

The preliminary committee will prepare and approve questions based on the agreed reading list to be administered during the written component of the preliminary exam.

The Preliminary examination **is not** a replacement for the dissertation proposal. Relevant research aspects of technology, methods, tools, applications, and canon must be addressed in the preliminary exam.

The Chair of the preliminary committee will submit preliminary questions to the Department Graduate Committee Chair(s) for review at least two weeks prior to the scheduled date of the written exam. The chair of the examining committee will assemble the written component of the preliminary exam and administer it to the student. Preliminary exam questions will be compiled in a repository for faculty review. The submission link is: https://purdue.ca1.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_3ek4QJgxTIPFmHc

The Chair of the preliminary committee will inform the student (and Preliminary Exam Committee, see attached Preliminary Exam Checklist) in writing when the reading list is approved.

The student will complete the written component of the preliminary exam within six weeks following approval of the reading list, depending on the nature of the questions, and the agreement of the examining committee. This time allotment will be communicated to the student, in writing, prior to the commencement of the written exam.

Students' responses to the preliminary questions will be evaluated by the preliminary committee members. The preliminary exam will be returned to the Chair of the preliminary committee by a method agreed to between the student and the Chair.

The Chair of the preliminary committee will schedule and lead a meeting of the full preliminary committee to discuss and evaluate written responses within two weeks of the submission of the written exam. The preliminary committee will determine whether the student has passed, or has not passed, the written component of the preliminary exam. To be evaluated as "Approved", the judgement of the majority of preliminary committee members prevails that the student has provided satisfactory responses to the written component of the exam. If a majority of preliminary committee members agree that the student has NOT provided satisfactory responses to the written component of the exam, the evaluation will be "No Pass". (See also Grading Procedures)

The Chair of the preliminary committee will notify the student in writing whether the written component of the preliminary exam is Approved or Not Approved within one week of the committee meeting. A copy of

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<https://catalog.purdue.edu/content.php?catoid=17&navoid=21844&hl=%22administering+graduate+programs%22&returnto=search#d-establishing-examining-committees>

this official letter (acknowledged by each member of the preliminary committee) is retained in the student's file. If "Approved", the Chair of the preliminary committee will schedule the oral component of the preliminary exam within two weeks of completing the evaluation of the written component. If "Not Approved", the oral component of the exam will not be held, and preliminary exam may be retaken (see procedures for administering a second preliminary exam).

The Chair of the preliminary committee will lead the oral component of the preliminary exam. The preliminary committee will have the opportunity to revisit questions from the written component of the preliminary exam for extension and/or clarification, and to ask the student additional follow up questions related to their written answers, drawing from the approved reading list and from the literatures in the student's area of study within the Polytechnic.

The student will be dismissed while the preliminary committee determines whether the oral component of the preliminary exam is Approved. The Chair of the preliminary committee will report the results of the oral preliminary exam to the student in writing within one week after the meeting with the preliminary committee. A copy of this official letter (acknowledged by each member of the preliminary committee) is retained in the student's file.

If the oral component of the preliminary exam is "Not Approved", the student may retake the preliminary exam (see procedures for administering a second preliminary exam). To progress in the program, both the written and oral components of the preliminary exam must be Approved in a single administration of the preliminary exam.

The Chair of the preliminary committee will report the results of the preliminary exam to the Graduate School using electronic Form 10.

5. Students with Disabilities

A student who requires accommodation in the preliminary examination procedures due to a disability needs to contact the Disability Resource Center (www.purdue.edu/drc). A member of that office will meet with the student, review their documentation, and recommend specific accommodations in the examination procedures to the Graduate Committee. To ensure that appropriate accommodation is made in preliminary examination procedures, students must contact the Disability Resource Center as soon as possible, but at least one semester prior to taking the preliminary exam. Once the DRC makes recommendations on the appropriate accommodations for a student, the chair of the committee will review and approve the recommended accommodations. If the accommodations threaten the validity of the preliminary exam, the chair will work with the DRC to final suitable, alternative accommodations.

6. Formatting the Written Component of the Preliminary Exam

The written component of the preliminary exam must be double-spaced with 1-inch margins on all sides, page numbers bottom center. The response to each question needs to be page-numbered separately. Each response must include a reference list. Students are expected to adhere to the current Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association. Note that each response must include its own reference list.

7. Independence and Academic Integrity.

The preliminary exam is to be completed independently by the student, without assistance from any other person.

- Students taking the preliminary exam **MAY**:
- Contact the Chair of the preliminary committee to ask about exam procedures or to clarify exam

questions (by email).

- Use any written resources obtained before the exam begins (noting restrictions in the section below).
- Use any written resources obtained during the exam, as long as they are found without help from another person (noting restrictions in the section below).
- Use Internet-based resources, as long as they are found without help from another person.

Students taking the preliminary exam **MAY NOT**:

- Consult with any person (except the Chair of the preliminary committee) in person, by phone, by email, or by Internet about exam questions, exam answers or resources needed to prepare exam answers.
- Receive assistance on the exam in any form from any person, including interpreting the questions, planning or writing the answers, or editing the text of the answers.
- Make use of prewritten papers from the Internet, in part or in whole.

The above rules do not cover every possible instance of academic dishonesty. Students are responsible for knowing about academic integrity contained in the Purdue University Code of Honor (http://www.purdue.edu/studentregulations/student_conduct/codeofhonor.html) and in "Academic Integrity: A Guide for Students" (<https://www.purdue.edu/odos/osrr/academic-integrity/index.html>) which states in part:

Purdue prohibits "dishonesty in connection with any University activity. Cheating, plagiarism, or knowingly furnishing false information to the University are examples of dishonesty." [*University Regulations, Part V, Section III, B, 2, a*] Furthermore, the University Senate has stipulated that "the commitment of acts of cheating, lying, and deceit in any of their diverse forms (such as the use of substitutes for taking examinations, the use of illegal cribs, plagiarism, and copying during examinations) is dishonest and must not be tolerated. Moreover, knowingly to aid and abet, directly or indirectly, other parties in committing dishonest acts is in itself dishonest." [University Senate Document 72-18, December 15, 1972]

Students are to contact the Chair of their preliminary committee by email if they have a question. The Chair of the preliminary committee can advise the student about the exam procedure and general questions of interpretation. The Chair cannot tell the student if a response is correct, nor can they provide any other help to the student in responding to the preliminary exam questions. Only the student taking the preliminary exam is to edit their responses. International students will have the same amount of time and follow the same rules as other students.

8. Grading Criteria

The grading criteria have been designed to be both fair to the student and constructive. The following criteria represent the framework for evaluating responses: accuracy/relevance, completeness, synthesis/integration, support, and writing and speaking style.

- Accuracy/Relevance: Accuracy reflects the correctness of a response. Accuracy also indicates the degree to which a response is, in fact, a response to the question asked, as opposed to a correct statement having little or nothing to do with the question.
- Completeness: Completeness is the degree to which the student considers all aspects of a question (i.e., the depth of the response considering the time frame allotted for the response). In the (frequent) case of a multi-part question, completeness also reflects whether the student addressed

all parts of the question in a balanced fashion.

- Synthesis/Integration: Preliminary exams are structured to encourage synthesis and integration. Rote responses and simple recitation of facts are inappropriate. What is desired is a consideration of a variety of facts, theories, and research findings in juxtaposition with other facts, theories, and research findings. The use of such skills helps to demonstrate a student's readiness to conceive and write an original dissertation.
- Literature Support: Students are expected to demonstrate their knowledge of pertinent and current or recent empirical and theoretical literature in responding to each question. The placement and format of citations need to be consistent with the current edition of the Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association (APA). Each response must include a reference list.
- Writing Style: The way a question is responded to is important. Responses must be clearly written, with well-defined terms and free of grammatical errors. Clear transitions between thoughts and arguments must follow a logical progression. Use of organizers (headers) is encouraged.
- Speaking Style (oral component): Like writing style, the manner in which each question is verbally answered is considered in the oral component of the preliminary exam. Verbal answers need to be clear and concise and presented in a logical fashion.

9. Procedures for Administering the Preliminary Exam – Student Responsibilities

When a student's written and oral components of the preliminary exam are Approved, the student will receive a **Pass** for the preliminary exam.

- When either a student's written or oral component of the preliminary exam is Not Approved, the student will receive a **No Pass** for the preliminary exam.
- Written Component: Using the above grading criteria, each preliminary committee member rates the written component of the preliminary exam as either **Approved** or **Not Approved**. When one or more committee members rate the written responses as **Not Approved**, the responses are discussed in detail by the entire preliminary committee. Following this discussion, a formal vote on the written component of the preliminary exam is taken. The judgment of the majority of the preliminary committee prevails in making a final decision as to whether the written component of the preliminary exam is **Approved**.
- A set of written responses that do not meet the grading criteria described in this handbook will be rated as **Not Approved** by the preliminary committee. This decision is not subject to debate or appeal once it has been made using procedures outlined in this handbook. The student will not complete an oral component of the preliminary exam and may complete a second preliminary exam (written and oral components) with new questions prepared by the preliminary committee as noted in section 10 of this document.
- Students are notified of the results of the written component of the preliminary exam by the Chair of the preliminary committee (acknowledged by each member of the preliminary committee). A copy of this notification is retained in the student's file.
- Oral Component: Using the above grading criteria and considering speaking style, each preliminary committee member rates the student's set of oral responses as either **Approved** or **Not Approved**. When one or more committee members rate the oral responses as Not Approved, the responses are discussed in detail by the entire preliminary committee. Following this discussion, a formal vote on the oral component of the preliminary exam is taken. The judgment of the majority of the preliminary committee members prevails in making a final decision as to whether the oral component of the preliminary exam is Approved.
- A set of oral responses that do not meet the grading criteria described in this handbook will be rated as **Not Approved** by the preliminary committee. This decision is not subject to debate or appeal once it has been made using procedures outlined in this handbook. The student may complete a second preliminary exam (written and oral components) with new questions prepared by the preliminary committee.
- Students are notified of the results of the oral component of the preliminary exam by the Chair of the preliminary committee (acknowledged by each member of the preliminary committee). A copy of this notification is retained in the student's file.
- The Graduate School of Purdue University recognizes only the broad categories of "satisfactory" or "unsatisfactory" of the entire preliminary exam. For a student to pass the preliminary exam, **both** the written and oral components must be evaluated as Approved in a single administration of the preliminary exam.

10. Procedures for Administering a Second Preliminary Exam

Procedures for preparing and administering a second preliminary exam (written and oral components) are the same as those described in this handbook for the first preliminary exam.

At the discretion of the preliminary committee, the original reading list may be revised for the second administration of the written component of the preliminary exam. **The student should complete the second preliminary exam no later than the end of the next immediate semester (Summer semester does not apply) following the administration of the first preliminary exam.**

- Written component:
 - When a student's written component of the preliminary exam is Not Approved, the student will receive a **No Pass** for the preliminary exam. The student will not complete an oral component of the preliminary exam.
- Oral component:
 - When a student's oral component of the preliminary exam is Not Approved, the student will receive a **No Pass** for the preliminary exam.

11. Procedures Following a Second Preliminary Exam

If a student does not successfully Pass the preliminary exam on the second administration, they will be terminated from the graduate program at the end of the semester in which the second exam is completed. The student and/or her or his committee have the option, before the end of that semester, to petition for retention in the program. Specific procedures can be found in Sections IX.A.2.c and VII.F.3 of the Policies and Procedures for Administering Graduate Student Programs of the Graduate School.

Strategies For Studying and Taking the Preliminary Exam:

The purpose of this section is to provide suggestions from the Graduate Committee regarding strategies that might prove helpful when studying for and taking the preliminary exam. The following should be taken in the spirit that they were given - they are suggestions, no more, no less. Everyone has their own favorite study strategies.

1. Preparation

- Read the Preliminary Handbook carefully before initiating the preliminary exam procedures.
- Keep in mind that the preliminary exam in part tests your integration and synthesis of accumulated knowledge. It will not be very useful to cram and memorize large amounts of material. Instead, stand back and get the "big picture." Never lose the big picture when you study. Ask yourself how one topic or issue relates to another. That is, actively construct your knowledge and new information into an integrated whole.
- Get excited about what you are studying. Think of yourself as becoming a scholar rather than just a reorganizer of facts. Study broadly with a focus on the topics identified in the approved reading list. These topics form the basis for each of the questions.
- Review research with an eye toward critiquing theoretical integration, design, interpretation of results, and applicability. Know the important elements of each selected reading.
- It might be useful to take one day off from studying during the week before the written component of the preliminary exam. Let the information simmer.
- Have a plan for using your time wisely during each component the preliminary exam.

2. Test Taking Tips

- Routinely and frequently back up your written work to prevent losing valuable time and information.
- Respond to the questions that are given. Make sure that you consider each sentence and clause within a given question--you must respond to each one.
- It is important that your responses be relevant to your area of study within the Polytechnic, and that they be supported by cited current literature.
- Remember that the major criteria for evaluation include organization, accuracy, depth, synthesis, being "on-target," and current literature support.
- Use citations liberally but not gratuitously. You should demonstrate your command of the literature, but it is counter-productive to cite a slew of studies or conceptual pieces that are only tangentially relevant to your responses. Avoid direct quotations that take up space.
- Organize your time. Proofread your written responses before handing them in. Be sure to check for APA Style in the body of the essay and citations as well as in the reference list

Preliminary Exam Checklists

1. Checklist for the Student

- ☐ Meet with advisor to discuss research topic and preliminary exam timeline.
- ☐ Develop a reading list related to research topic.
- ☐ Submit the reading list to the preliminary exam committee for approval.
- ☐ Receive approval/revisions from the committee within 2 weeks.
- ☐ Review and prepare for the exam based on the approved reading list.
- ☐ Confirm the scheduled dates for the written and oral components with the committee.
- ☐ Complete the written exam within 6 weeks of reading list approval.
- ☐ Submit written responses to the committee immediately after completion.
- ☐ Prepare for the oral exam (if the written component is approved).
- ☐ Attend the oral exam and respond to the committee's questions.
- ☐ Receive official notification of exam results from the Chair.
- ☐ If passed, ensure Form 10 is submitted to the Graduate School.
- ☐ If not passed, discuss next steps with the committee and prepare for the second attempt (if applicable).

2. Checklist for the Chair of the Examining Committee

- ☐ Advise student on expectations and timeline for the preliminary exam.
- ☐ Review and approve/revise the student's reading list within 2 weeks of submission.
- ☐ Coordinate with the preliminary exam committee to finalize exam questions.
- ☐ Submit exam questions to the Department Graduate Committee Chair(s) for review (2 weeks before the exam).
- ☐ Schedule and confirm the written exam date with the student and committee.
- ☐ Administer the written exam and collect responses.
- ☐ Distribute the student's written responses to the committee for evaluation.
- ☐ Schedule and lead a meeting to review and evaluate written responses within 2 weeks of submission.
- ☐ Notify the student in writing whether the written exam is approved or not (within 1 week of committee review).
- ☐ If approved, schedule the oral exam within 2 weeks.
- ☐ Lead the oral exam session and facilitate follow-up questions.
- ☐ Hold committee discussion after the oral exam to determine results.
- ☐ Notify the student in writing of the oral exam outcome (within 1 week).
- ☐ Submit Form 10 to the Graduate School if the student passes.
- ☐ If the student does not pass, advise on next steps and potential second attempt process.

Preliminary Exam Timeline

Step	Task	Responsible Party	Deadline
Step 1	Develop a reading list related to research topic	Student	At least 10 weeks before the exam
Step 2	Submit the reading list to the preliminary exam committee for approval	Student	9 weeks before the exam
Step 3	Review and approve/revise the reading list	Preliminary Exam Committee	Within 2 weeks of receiving the list
Step 4	Finalize the exam questions based on the approved reading list	Preliminary Exam Committee	7 weeks before the exam
Step 5	Submit exam questions to the Department Graduate Committee Chair(s) for review	Chair of the Preliminary Exam Committee	6 weeks before the exam
Step 6	Schedule the written component of the exam	Chair of the Preliminary Exam Committee	At least 4 weeks before the exam
Step 7	Administer the written exam	Student	Scheduled date
Step 8	Submit written responses to the committee for evaluation	Student	Immediately after completion of written exam
Step 9	Committee reviews and evaluates written responses	Preliminary Exam Committee	Within 2 weeks of submission
Step 10	Notify the student of the written exam outcome (Approved/Not Approved)	Chair of the Preliminary Exam Committee	Within 1 week of committee review
Step 11	If approved, schedule the oral component of the exam	Chair of the Preliminary Exam Committee	Within 2 weeks after written approval
Step 12	Conduct the oral exam	Student & Committee	Scheduled date
Step 13	Committee evaluates the oral exam performance	Preliminary Exam Committee	Immediately after oral exam
Step 14	Notify the student of	Chair of the	Within 1 week of oral

	oral exam outcome (Approved/Not Approved)	Preliminary Exam Committee	exam
Step 15	If student passes both written and oral components, submit Form 10 to the Graduate School	Chair of the Preliminary Exam Committee	Within 1 week after passing
Step 16	If student does not pass, determine next steps for retake process	Preliminary Exam Committee & Student	As soon as possible